

TABLE 1

Differential Diagnosis for the Common Cold

Diagnosis	Symptom onset	Cough	Sore throat	Fever	Rhinorrhea	Aches	Watery eyes	Sneezing	Nasal congestion	Headache	Shortness of breath
Acute bronchitis	Gradual	Prominent, persistent, dry or wet	Common	None or low grade	Uncommon	Mild	Common	Uncommon	Uncommon	Common, mild	Common
Allergic rhinitis	Gradual	Common, chronic	Possible, especially on awakening	None	Common, prominent	None	Common	Prominent	Common	Uncommon	Uncommon
Bacterial sinusitis	Gradual	Common	Common	Common	Common	Common	Uncommon	Uncommon	Common	Common	Uncommon
Common cold	Gradual	Common, dry	Common	None or low grade	Common	Mild	Common	Common	Common	Common, mild	Uncommon
Influenza	Abrupt	Common, dry hacking	Common	Characteristic; high and rises rapidly	Common	Early, prominent	Uncommon	Uncommon	Possible	Prominent	Uncommon
Pertussis	Gradual	Prominent, paroxysmal, whoop-like	Uncommon	None or low grade	Uncommon	Uncommon	Uncommon	Uncommon	Uncommon	Uncommon	Common
Pharyngitis	Gradual	Uncommon	Characteristic; prominent	Variable (low grade if viral, high if bacterial)	Common	Can be severe if bacterial	Common	Common if viral	Uncommon	Common; mild if viral, severe if bacterial	Uncommon